

Two in Five Americans Own No Stock at All

You will see a clean four way split of who owns what quoted as fact. **It is not published anywhere.** Here is what was measured, what had to be inferred, and how to tell them apart.

01 The count

58 percent of US adults own stock in some form, about 156 million people. **42 percent own none at all.** That 58 is down from 62: participation fell while the index rose.

It sits in two different containers. **61 percent** have a tax preferred retirement account (a 401k, IRA or Roth, where the tax break is the point). **37 percent** have a taxable brokerage account (an ordinary investing account, no tax wrapper). Those two totals are published. **How they overlap is not.**

02 The overlap

Imagine a school that counted how many children play soccer, and counted how many play piano, and never wrote down how many do both. You can still say a lot. You cannot say that one thing.

More US adults hold no account at all than hold both

Share of US adults. Every adult sits in exactly one of these four.



Fed SHED 2025, published May 2026, measured: 61 percent hold a retirement account, 37 percent a taxable one. The four way split is derived, and is the only one reproducing both of those totals while summing to 100.

- **Only two numbers here were measured: 61 and 37.** The four way split is derived, assuming 85 to 90 percent of taxable holders also hold a retirement account.
- **The 33 percent holding both is the number nobody published.** It is the only value that holds the two measured totals together: 28 plus 33 is 61, four plus 33 is 37, all four sum to 100.
- **35 percent hold neither account, yet 42 percent own no stock.** Not a contradiction: the Fed asks whether an account EXISTS, Gallup asks about stock EXPOSURE, and a 401k can sit entirely in cash.

BOTTOM LINE

Before you quote a statistic, ask which question was actually asked. Quote 61, 37 and 42 percent, which are measured. The tidy four way split is an estimate wearing the clothes of a measurement.

SOURCES & NOTE

Sources: Federal Reserve SHED 2025 (published May 2026) for 61 and 37 percent; Gallup April 2026 for 58 and 42 percent. The four cell split is derived, not published. Educational, not financial advice.